laughable, and French the same. He not only translates his English ideas and idiom literally into either of these languages he may be speaking, but often English slang. And the most extraordinary thing is, that altho he makes his hearers roar with laughter, they almost always understand him. He has been away at Erzeroom and Baghdad two years endeavouring to arrange the disputes between Persia and Turkey and has, during that time seen dangers and hardships enough to fill a novel.

I have been out to day digging crocus roots. It appears that some people in Europe have a *croco-mania:* for some years back Mr Cartwright of Constantinople has been writing to all his friends to get him wild crocus bulbs. Why I can not tell for they are neither so pretty nor half so large as those we have in England. We have never been able to find him any: those bulbs we have sent have turned out to be a small ugly and very common kind of tulip, I believe I have at last found some which answer his description. I mean to keep the roots and send him on a few of the flowers, and send the roots if he writes for them. Some of the wild flowers on the hills of Persia are very beautiful and many I believe unknown to the botanists. I am told that the hills about Ouroumia abound in flowers and that the common white lilly which is such a showy flower in our gardens in England, there, grows wild in the greatest perfection. The contrast between the flowery hills rocks and mountains, and the dry, salt, arid, barren plains is most remarkable and delightful.

Mount Elwund and Hamadan,[87] one of the highest mountains in Persia, perhaps nearly as high as Ararat, is famous for its flowers and most marvelous stories are told about the effects of some of the herbs and flowers gathered there. Persians have assured me that many people come from India, at a certain season to gather herbs on this mountain; which herbs are to be used in the process of turning all metals into gold, which we call the philosophers stone, and the Persians "Kimia," from a Greek word. I believe our word Chymistry is derived from the same source.[88] The belief in this art is still strong in Persia, and many expend their whole fortunes in pursuing it. And they firmly believe that some people succeed. A man who had expended large sums in this pursuit told me he was certain that success was possible, but that it is attended with a curse, and he who discovers the secret is doomed to live and die in the most abject misery. You will find a strange story of this kind in a book called "Journey through Asia Minor, Armenia etc by John MacDonald Kenneir John Murray Albemarl

[87] Mt. Elwend, the classical Orontes, is about 17,560 feet high. Hamadhan, the adjacent district, owes its fertility to the wealth of water and snow from the mountain.

[88] Edward's etymology is, of course, correct, except that the Persians received this word, like many similar ones, through the Arabic.

Generated on 2020-09-16 00:02 GMT / https://hdl.handle.net/2027/mdp.39015035112393
Public Domain, Google-digitized / http://www.hathitrust.org/access_use#pd-google
Digitized by Google
Original from UNIVERSITY OF MICHIGAN